I went to well over thirty schools in all. It was just that kind of life, in which consistency was a matter of style and values, not of where you parked your car or how you paid your debts. Later on in my childhood, the peripatetic existence became more hysterical. We were later much more like fugitives, my mother and I. But early on, it was heavenly. And it gave me a sense of meeting new challenges all the time. With mum and Brett, it felt like we were gulping down experience without fear. During that early period, I had a happy childhood, and it was partly to do with the joy of discovery and the certainty that rules were there to be broken.

Within the little gangs I headed up we had our share of children's wisdom and a whole stack of prejudice. At one time, I think we felt the Italians were a sort of adversary. They had this habit of paving. They'd buy a house with bougainvillea outside, this wonderful blush of colour, and would immediately clear it all and pave the garden and put up Doric columns. I'm ashamed of it now, but I took against this. It seemed important to me then to take a stand against this thing. I was probably the kind of child who was shopping for things to take a stand against. I remember one day my folks were making dinner and found they were short of tomatoes. The Italian neighbours had loads of tomatoes. My mother had asked for some and had been refused, and this got to me. So the next day I began digging a tunnel from our garden to theirs. I got some of my little gang involved, bringing shovels and candles to get the job done. It was hard work, but we got under the fence in secret and came away with two baskets of tomatoes. I handed one of them to my mother and she had this grin. We waited to see what would happen, and what happened was that two policemen quickly turned up at the door and they, too, were grinning. The policeman just stood there rocking on their heels. It was my first run-in with the law. We handed back one basket of tomatoes, and the scandal reverberated. But I was happy that I still had the second basket of tomatoes hidden.

I don't know if I was eccentric or whatever, but I know I was single-minded. They sent me to some kind of Steiner-style school where it was all about expressing yourself. There was a scooter, I remember, and an obnoxious little girl who wouldn't share. In accordance with the school's philosophy, I decided to express myself without hindrance, so I hit the girl over the head with a hammer. This caused a giant fuss, of course, and I had to leave, although the girl was fine.